Shellnight 2026–27: Your Guide to Turtle Nesting Season

Sai Kaew Thong Beach Resort, Khao Lak, Phang Nga · Guest leaflet GX-LF-2026-09 · Issued 15 October 2026

1. Welcome to Shellnight

Every year sea turtles come ashore on the 1.8 km beach in front of Sai Kaew Thong Beach Resort to lay their eggs. Shellnight is the resort's guest programme for the nesting season. It explains how the beach changes after dark, what we ask of every guest, and the turtle activities you can join during your stay. This leaflet is placed in every room and villa and is also available at the Reef Desk in the main lobby.

The 2026–27 Shellnight season runs from **1 November 2026 to 30 April 2027**. Most nests are laid between December and February, and most hatchlings emerge between February and April. Last season our patrol team recorded 31 nests and 2,140 hatchlings reaching the sea, the highest numbers since the programme began in 2019.

The programme is led by the resort naturalist, Thanakorn Wisetsri, together with a team of six night patrol staff. Guest-facing arrangements, bookings and complaints are handled by the Guest Experience Manager, Pimchanok Saelim.

2. Which turtles nest here

Two species use our beach. Olive ridley turtles make up most nests. They are small (about 65 cm shell length), usually arrive between 21:00 and 02:00, and spend around 45 minutes on the sand. Green turtles are less frequent visitors, with three nests last season. They are much larger and can spend up to two hours digging and covering a nest.

A female digs a body pit, lays around 100 eggs in a flask-shaped chamber and covers it before returning to the sea. Eggs incubate in the warm sand for roughly 50 to 60 days.

Nesting turtles are easily disturbed. A turtle that sees light, movement or people near the water will often turn back without laying, and may then lay her eggs in the sea, where they are lost. Hatchlings find the sea by heading towards the brightest horizon. Lights from rooms, phones or torches can lead them inland, where they die of heat or are taken by crabs and dogs. The rules in this leaflet are designed around these two facts.

3. Beach quiet hours and lighting

During the season the beach and all beach-facing areas follow **quiet hours from 19:00 to 05:30** every night. Until last season quiet hours began at 20:00; the earlier start was introduced after the patrol team recorded several turtles arriving before 20:00 in 2025–26.

During quiet hours:

- Path and garden lights on the beach side switch automatically to low amber lamps at 19:00.
- Beachfront Pool Villas (villas B01 to B24) and Sea View Deluxe rooms on floors 1 and 2 of the Ocean Wing must keep their beach-facing curtains closed while lights are on inside. Terrace lights must stay off; each terrace has a red-light lantern for use after 19:00.

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- Torches, phone lights and camera flashes may not be used on the sand. The Reef Desk lends red-filter torches free of charge against your room key.
- The Driftwood Beach Bar stops serving on the sand at 19:00 and continues on its raised deck until 22:00. Outside the season the bar serves on the sand until 23:00.
- Sun loungers and umbrellas are stacked behind the dune line by 18:30 so that turtles have a clear path.

Note. The Lagoon Pool on the garden side is not part of the quiet-hours zone and keeps its normal opening hours until 22:00. The Beach Pool closes at 18:30 during the season instead of 20:00.

4. If you see a turtle on the beach

Turtles may come ashore anywhere along the beach, including right in front of the villas. If you see a turtle, or tracks that look like a tractor tyre leading up from the water, please follow these steps:

1. Stop where you are and stay low. Keep at least 15 metres away from the turtle and never stand between her and the sea.
2. Switch off every light, including phone screens. Do not take photographs at this stage.
3. Note the number of the nearest white beach marker post. Posts are numbered S1 to S18 from the southern rocks to the river mouth.
4. Call the Shellnight Turtle Line on room extension 7700, or 076 488 270 from a mobile phone. The line is staffed from 18:00 to 06:00 throughout the season.
5. Wait quietly at your position until a patrol member arrives, normally within 10 minutes. The patrol member will tell you whether you may stay and watch.

Once a turtle has started laying she is less sensitive, and the patrol member may invite you to watch from behind her using a red light. Please do not touch the turtle, the eggs or the tracks. After she has returned to the sea the patrol marks the nest with a bamboo fence and a numbered sign.

Note. If you find a turtle that is injured, tangled in netting or stranded during the day, call the Turtle Line straight away even outside its staffed hours. Calls between 06:00 and 18:00 are forwarded to the Reef Desk, which can reach the naturalist at any time.

5. Shellnight activities

Night Nest Walk

A guided walk along the beach with a patrol member, looking for nesting turtles and checking marked nests. Walks run on Tuesdays, Thursdays and Saturdays at 20:30 and last about 90 minutes. Each walk is limited to 12 guests. The price is 650 baht per adult and 350 baht per child aged 8 to 12. The minimum age is 8 years, because the walk takes place in near-total darkness and requires guests to stay silent for long periods. Children aged 8 to 12 must be accompanied by a participating adult. Sightings cannot be guaranteed: last season a nesting turtle was seen on 38 % of walks.

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Hatchling release

When a marked nest begins to hatch, the patrol team guides the hatchlings safely to the water and invites guests to watch from a roped line. Releases usually happen at dusk or before dawn and are announced with no more than three hours' notice. To be called, add your name and room number to the Hatchling List at the Reef Desk; the desk will phone your room. Releases are free and open to guests of all ages, including young children, provided they stay behind the rope with an adult. Guests may not handle hatchlings.

Nest Talk

A 45-minute illustrated talk by Thanakorn Wisetsri on turtle biology and the work of the patrol, held every Wednesday at 17:00 in the Lagoon Room. Free, no booking needed, suitable for all ages.

6. Booking and cancellation

Night Nest Walks can be booked at the Reef Desk (open 08:00 to 20:00), through the resort app, or by calling extension 7710. Bookings close at 18:00 on the day of the walk. The fee is charged to your room account at the time of booking.

Guests who cancel before 15:00 on the day of the walk receive a full refund. Cancellations between 15:00 and 18:00 are refunded at 50 %, and no refund is given for cancellations after 18:00 or for guests who do not arrive at the meeting point. If the resort cancels a walk because of heavy rain, high surf or lightning, booked guests are offered either a full refund or a free place on the next available walk during their stay. A guest who arrives late after the group has left cannot join that walk, as the group cannot return to the start without disturbing the beach.

Note. Guests with a medical certificate showing illness on the day are refunded in full whatever the time of cancellation. Please show the certificate at the Reef Desk within 24 hours.

7. Other beach rules during the season

- No beach fires, lanterns or fireworks at any time, including at private villa events.
- Holes dug in the sand must be filled in and sandcastles flattened before 18:00, as hatchlings can become trapped.
- Drones may not be flown over the beach between 18:00 and 06:00.
- Kayaks and paddleboards are available as usual from 08:00 to 17:30 but must not be landed inside a fenced nest area.
- Dogs belonging to guests are not permitted on the beach during the season.
- Private beach dinners are still available but move to the Driftwood deck after 19:00.

8. Contacts

- Shellnight Turtle Line: extension 7700, or 076 488 270 (18:00 to 06:00)
- Reef Desk, main lobby: extension 7710 (08:00 to 20:00)
- Guest Experience Manager, Pimchanok Saelim: guest.experience@saikaewthong.example

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